

Checklist

Tech Senior Leadership Checklist

Lead first

- ☐ Set the tone for how people act, think, and work together
- ☐ Be clear about what the organization should value
- ☐ Make hard decisions without waiting for perfect information
- ☐ Understand the business context, not just the technical one
- ☐ Help the organization follow through on needed change
- ☐ Hold people and teams accountable for outcomes
- ☐ Disagree when needed, then commit once a decision is made

Do the four core management tasks

- ☐ Gather information from meetings, docs, 1:1s, and stakeholders
- ☐ Synthesize large amounts of information quickly
- ☐ Share the right information with the right people in a usable way
- ☐ Nudge instead of over-commanding
- ☐ Make decisions from conflicting and incomplete inputs
- ☐ Role-model the company's values and commitments

Know your role

- ☐ Clarify whether your role is primarily R&D, strategy, organization, execution, external-facing, infrastructure, or business-oriented
- ☐ Match your time to the real needs of the company's stage
- ☐ Avoid assuming titles mean the same thing at every company
- ☐ Reassess your role as the company grows

If you are a VP of Engineering

- Own day-to-day execution and operational health
- Track multiple initiatives without losing the details
- Align roadmap, hiring plan, and team structure
- Coach managers and grow leadership on the team
- Improve processes and organizational effectiveness
- Build trust through management strength and technical credibility
- Stay close enough to the work to understand what is really happening

If you are a CTO

- ☐ Treat the role as a business strategy job, not a pure engineering job
- ☐ Shape business strategy through the lens of technology
- ☐ Focus on the company's current stage of evolution
- ☐ Maintain enough management influence to move the organization
- ☐ Protect the tech team from becoming a feature factory for others
- ☐ Keep reporting power or equivalent influence where it matters
- ☐ Stay accountable for both technical direction and organizational outcomes

Change priorities well

- ☐ Confirm the true top priority before demanding a shift
- ☐ Explicitly decide what will stop, slip, or be deprioritized
- ☐ Communicate changes up, down, and across the org
- ☐ Make sure everyone shares the same understanding of reality
- ☐ Repeat key messages more than once
- ☐ Push for clarity on tradeoffs, timelines, and in-flight work
- ☐ Help teams change direction without chaos

Set strategy

- ☐ Research the team, systems, bottlenecks, and business direction
- ☐ Talk to executives, peers, and engineers before drafting a strategy
- ☐ Combine evidence with your own judgment
- ☐ Turn broad ideas into actionable plans
- ☐ Think about architecture, team structure, and future business needs together
- ☐ Tailor strategy communication to the audience, especially the board

- ☐ Make strategy forward-looking, not just reactive

Deliver bad news well

- ☐ Do not rely on impersonal mass messages for sensitive news
- ☐ Talk to key individuals first when possible
- ☐ Be honest about likely outcomes
- ☐ Do not deliver a message you fundamentally cannot stand behind alone
- ☐ Use trusted lieutenants, managers, or HR when appropriate
- ☐ Think about how you would want to hear the news yourself

Manage a nontechnical boss

- ☐ Avoid jargon and unnecessary technical detail
- ☐ Come to 1:1s prepared with a clear agenda
- ☐ Bring solutions, not just problems
- ☐ Ask for advice respectfully
- ☐ Repeat important issues when needed
- ☐ Show support and initiative
- ☐ Find coaching and development outside of your boss if necessary

Work well with senior peers

- ☐ Respect peers' ownership of their areas
- ☐ Let peers make decisions in their own domain
- ☐ Address disagreements directly and kindly
- ☐ Build trust across different working styles
- ☐ Avoid undermining peers in front of the wider org
- ☐ Present a united front after decisions are made
- ☐ Communicate technical complexity in a way nontechnical peers can understand

Understand “the echo” of leadership

- ☐ Remember that your words carry extra weight
- ☐ Avoid over-socializing with direct reports in ways that create favoritism
- ☐ Detach enough to lead clearly and fairly
- ☐ Be careful not to accidentally redirect work through casual comments

- ☐ Model the behavior you want copied
- ☐ Do not dump executive anxieties onto your team
- ☐ Stay human and caring without slipping back into “buddy” mode

Build trust, not fear

- ☐ Notice whether people seem afraid to take risks around you
- ☐ Practice relatedness and basic human connection
- ☐ Apologize honestly and briefly when you mess up
- ☐ Get curious before reacting or attacking
- ☐ Treat disagreement as information, not disloyalty
- ☐ Hold people accountable without humiliating them
- ☐ Create safety for questions, mistakes, and learning

Define your team’s True North

- ☐ Be explicit about what excellence means in your function
- ☐ Define the standards your team should use in judgment calls
- ☐ Use risk analysis instead of absolutism
- ☐ Decide what kinds of risks are acceptable and when
- ☐ Protect quality, readiness, and operational standards
- ☐ Teach your leaders to make fast decisions using these principles
- ☐ Revisit standards as the company and systems evolve

Assess yourself regularly

- ☐ Get coaching or mentorship outside your company
- ☐ Build a peer network outside your workplace
- ☐ Identify senior leaders you admire and why
- ☐ Review how you handled your last priority shift
- ☐ Check whether you understand the company’s future and bottlenecks
- ☐ Audit your relationships with the senior leadership team
- ☐ Ask whether your team sees you as a role model
- ☐ Examine whether you listen enough
- ☐ Stay connected to people as humans, not just as resources
- ☐ Clarify the principles you want your managers and engineers to follow

